



Microsoft Outlook 2003

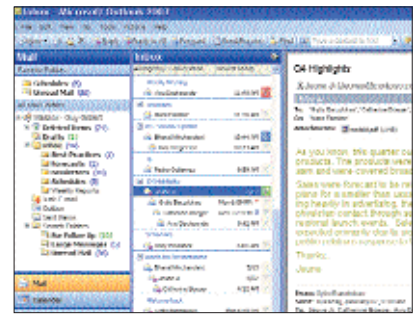
Microsoft Outlook 2003 comes bundled with Microsoft Office 2003, but is also available as a standalone product. The interface consists of a shortcuts panel where the different features can be quickly accessed; the Folder List and a third pane is where you can view the features activated from the shortcuts panel. It can be a bit confusing in the beginning, but a closer look reveals that everything is in a proper, logical order. Keep in mind that this is primarily a PIM client, and the e-mail client is only a part of it.

Outlook supports the POP3 and IMAP protocols, and you can also connect to HTTP e-mail servers such as Hotmail. The real power of Outlook is realised only after it connects to the MS Exchange Server, but you won't see this as a home user.

You can compose great-looking HTML mails thanks to its integration with Word as an e-mail

editor. The spell-checker is the same that comes with MS Office, so you can expect it to work very well. You can add ActiveX content to the mail using Word. This opens the door of vulnerability to viruses and worms, but thankfully, Microsoft periodically issues security updates to patch holes in Outlook—just remember to update!

Outlook 2003 comes with a good spam filter that efficiently weeds out most spam. You can even set the level of filtering. By default, messages are sorted by date, and are arranged into groups. You can also set messages to display as threaded chains. Since this is a product aimed primarily at the corporate user, it comes with PIM features such as Calendar, Notes, and Tasks. It costs \$109 (Rs 4,900)—too steep a price for a home user!



The three-pane interface of Outlook 2003



Outlook Express 6.0

Outlook Express 6.0 (OE) is part of Windows XP and has a very simple and easy-to-use interface. It is well integrated with the OS and also with Internet Explorer. An e-mail setup wizard launches on your first run, and guides you to set up your account with no hassles. Due to its integration with Windows, it performs with ease and speed.

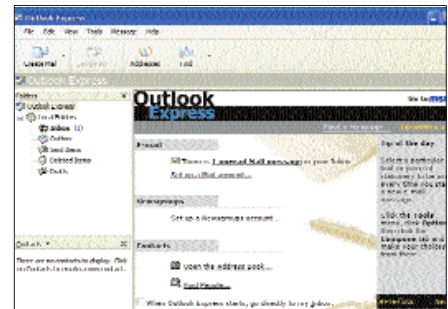
Along with the usual POP3 and IMAP, you can also set up newsgroup accounts, or even LDAP for that matter.

Though you can create HTML messages in OE, there are certain limitations. While replying with HTML formatting, you cannot insert lines below the quoted message or within it because of the irritating vertical line that appears to the left

of the quoted text. Plus, you can only add simple backgrounds to your e-mails.

It is easy to arrange mail in different virtual folders, and you can easily create rules that automatically transport e-mails to the required folders.

Integration with MSN Messenger lets you synchronise contacts between the two. You get all this at a price: Outlook Express is one of the least secure e-mail clients, and is rather vulnerable to attacks by worms and viruses. But then, do you find computers around that are not protected by an anti-virus these days?



Outlook Express—it's right there



Pegasus 4.4

Pegasus is one of the oldest e-mail clients around, having first been launched in 1990. The interface is far from polished—the functionality is there, but is in scattered form, and takes time to get comfortable with. Thankfully, it comes with an exhaustive help system.

All messages you send are stored in a folder named "Copies to self"—realise that that's the correct way of addressing sent mail! The Main Folder contains all the mails it receives, but there is a New mail folder that contains unread mails, so you don't have to search for an old mail you forgot to read.

You can sort messages by thread, sender, date, and more criteria. Public folders allow multiple users to share access to the same messages in Pegasus Mail.

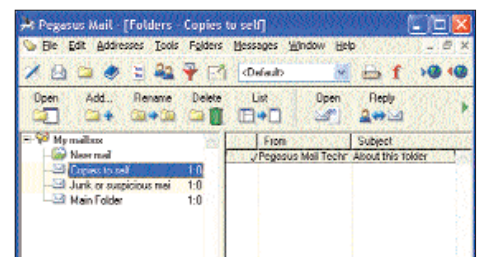
Pegasus supports POP3 and SMTP, and can also manage multiple accounts of each type.

Unfortunately, it does not support Atom or RSS feeds.

HTML-formatted mails can be composed in Pegasus. The Glossary lets you store a list of abbreviations and their long forms, so that you can use and expand them in mails at the click of a button.

While Pegasus has an extensive e-mail filtering system and is highly configurable, it is likely that the general user would be left confused because of the lack of Wizards for this purpose. The Bayesian filter takes care of spam, while the integrated phishing protection alerts you about malicious Web sites.

You can review your mail on the POP3 server and choose to directly delete it if you so wish. Along with TSL/SSL, Pegasus can also work with third-party e-mail encryption solutions.



The Sent Items folder is called *Copies to self!*